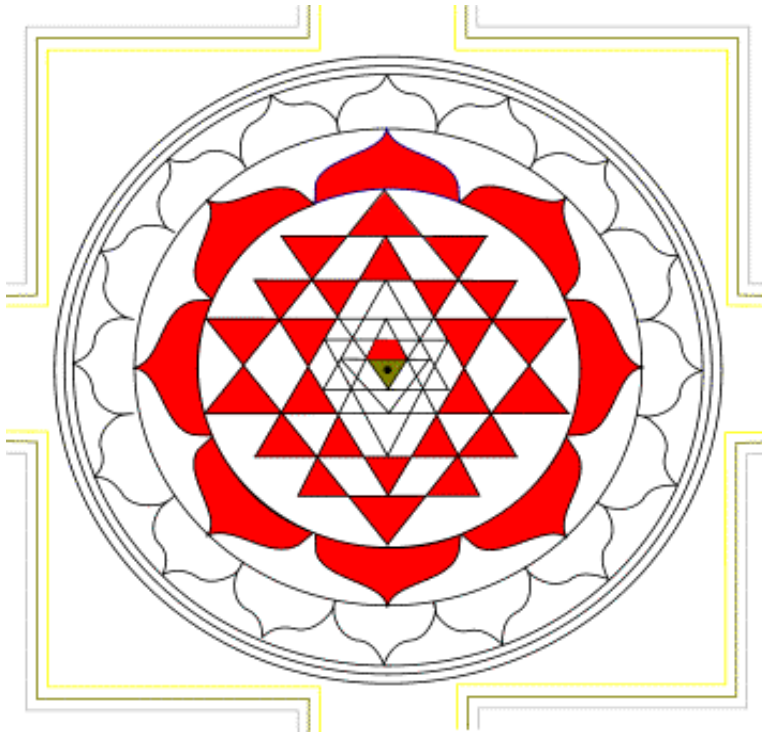




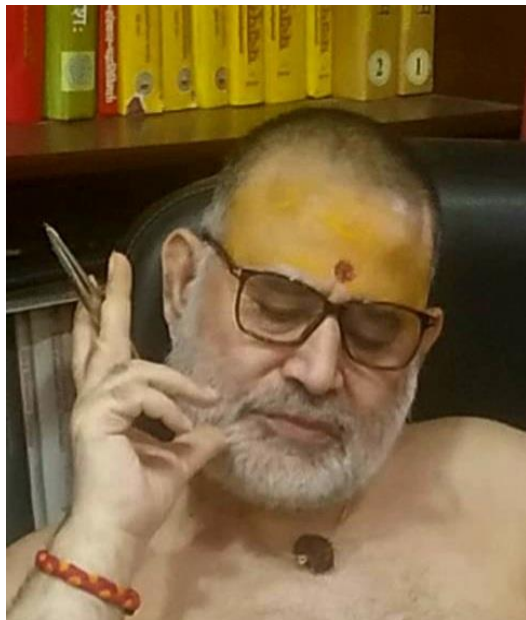
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From the Chief Editor's Desk

इदमहमनृतात् सत्यमभियुपैमि

Thus I attain the truth from falsehood

Revert back to atheism and start your pursuit afresh said Shri Aurobindo, instead of following

a commitment based on faulty convictions . And then pursue the path to perfection from the scratch . The great exponent of atheism or let us say anti theism Nietzsche is correct in as much as it takes to reject an aberrant conviction. But this should not be the finale . The motivation for a flawless commitment and metaphysical truth as

the corollary of absorption into one's essential nature must persist .

Metaphysical portion of the Vedas, the Upanishads begin with a blatant rejection of conventional notion of truth. Votaries of the absolute brahman reflected in their caucus, what is the primordial cause , what is the agency which accounts for our origin and sustenance so on and so forth. Dry discursive reasoning based on revelations did not suffice hence they resorted to meditation and in a deep meditative trance of yoga they had an insight into the “divine Shakti veiled within the orb of her own guns or virtues

“Know this to be the truth and not what is conventionally worshiped by hoipoloi”

विज्ञातमविज्ञानतामविज्ञातंविज्ञानताम्*

It is known to those who knows not and unknown to those who know not. Agamas begin with downright atheism and it produces the woes of not believing in god as creator and the revelations . Some thinkers have interpreted atheism (based on sanskrit etymology nastikyam)as rejection of the theory of karma which is akin to existantialism. Agamas and tantra unlike yoga and other ethics based creeds do not begin high gradations of moral perfection. Instead they begin with your immediate infatuation with lower nature, lust ,wrath, greed, delusion, vanity, malice, virtue and vices. Sublimating lower base nature takes more effort than to assume that you have attained the requisite degree of moral perfection for sitting in a yogic seance. Agamic and tantric yoga is devised for an aspirant of meagre competence but the process and attainment are authentic and substantial . The process of initiation consisting of severing the bondage through infusion of spiritual power cuts-short the assiduous course of attaining the requisite and the impetus is provided through the use of uninterrupted lineage of preceptors . In the verbiage of dialectic Vedanta the tradition of unexpressed transference of the purport of the great dictum

निर्विकल्पवाक्यार्थोपस्थितिः *

There is no alternative except seeming resort to agamic means which are commonly called upayas .

आचार्यः सत्कुलोद्भवःलब्धागमः a preceptor as one tantric canon goes must be born an elite, must have inherited the lineage of agamas specially when it comes to the propagation of a lineage based on “word transcendental “subjective experience .

*तत्त्वकारः

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Editorial



True faith does not come easy especially in the contemporary postmodern era where humanity is beset with skepticism and constantly living in the feeling of doubt and mistrust. Time and again this excess dependence on reasonable calculations has been proved futile yet we harken back to it. The danger of too much rationality was realized during the world wars and soon started the explorations into the dark recesses of the mind where lurked the hidden and many a times forbidden desires and thoughts. Surrealism as an art movement and a reaction to world wars changed the face of western art and cinema for ever. With Freud and Jung, the importance of dreams, mythological symbolism and archetypes was realized. The intense need to address the parts of oneself which conventional mindset had conveniently shoved under the carpet raised its head. Along with the light came the idea of embracing the dark.

It is to become aware about these parts of our own self and the immense power possessed by them that tantras are devised. To see our self in totality, negating nothing, coming face to face with the darker side and transform it with awareness and compassion is what is needed and what has been needed in this world. Once one acknowledges one's weaknesses and flaws it is easier to work on them and the journey of transformation becomes truly meaningful.

Carl Jung, the renowned psychiatrist and psychoanalyst opines

“Until you make the unconscious conscious, it will direct your life and you will call it fate”

Explaining the notion we begin with the insightful editorial by our Guru Maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirth ji on the nature of tantras and the concept of sublimation of base desires.

“Agamas and tantra unlike yoga and other ethics based creeds do not begin high gradations of moral perfection. Instead they begin with your immediate infatuation with lower nature, lust, wrath, greed, delusion, vanity, malice, virtue and vices.”writes Swamiji

Next we have translation and exposition of last three verse of ‘Neel Saraswati Stotram’ from ‘Brihanneel Tantra’. These verses overflow with love and devotion for Ma Tara and suggest that a true devotee of hers will attain all material and supernatural powers with her unlimited grace. Following this we have an erudite article titled ‘Mind, the Organ of Brain’ by Dr G.L Kaw in which he muses about his explorations in the nature of mind and its functions since his student days. Coming next we have an interesting academic write-up by Bhoomi Sati on ‘Yoga and Neuroplasticity’ where she explores the benefits of incorporating yoga in ones life.

This is followed by an engaging travelogue by Rashneek Kher narrating his experiences during his first visit to Tarakund. Next up there is translation and exposition on first five karikas from Ishwar Pratibhijna Karika by Utpaladeva from the YTA study circle. Subsequently we have a brief write-up on ‘The Science of Shakti’ by Varni Paratpar Swarup quoting the verses from ‘Shakti Vijnana’ and their detailed exposition. A brief insight into the online classes conducted by YTA is next which is followed by a passionate poem titled ‘After the Rain’ by Prof Ambika Talwar, expressing the deep set love for the beauty abounding in nature.



(Kimiya)

NEEL SARASWATI STOTRAM

(A Hymn to the sapphire goddess of wisdom
from Brihanneel Tantra)



ताराष्टकमिदं रम्यं भक्तिमान् यः पठेन्नरः।

प्रातर्मध्याह्नकाले च सायाह्ने नियतः शुचिः ॥ ९ ॥

A man who recites these eight verse of
mother Tara in the morning noon and
evening with devotion
regularly and after ablution and
purifying oneself

लभते कवितां दिव्यां सर्वशास्त्रार्थविद् भवेत्।

लक्ष्मीमनश्चरां प्राप्य भुक्त्वा भोगान् यथेप्सितान् ॥

१० ॥--Attains divine poesy and knows the
meaning of all scriptures. He attains
incessant wealth and having
enjoyed all worldly pleasures

कीर्तिं कान्तिं च नैरुज्यं सर्वेषां प्रियतां व्रजेत्।

विख्यातिं चैव लोकेषु प्राप्यान्ते मोक्षमाप्नुयात् ॥

११ ॥

-Attains fame brilliance health .Any one
who recites this hymn becomes
agreeable to every one and after being
renowned in this world he attains
salvation

Mind- The Organ of Brain



Dr G.L Kaw

It was decades ago, when my physiology teacher while concluding a class on functions of the fore brain declared that, “Mind is the organ of the brain.” Since I was a front bencher in this class for some particular reasons, I heard the statement loud and clear but could not believe my ears, as it sounded like a new revelation and not in line with our knowledge of anatomy and physiology at that time. I was a second year medical student then, and one could have taken this one liner as a routine off the cuff remark of a teacher. But this teacher was not an ordinary teacher. He was one of the most respected and recognized physiologists of Asia at that time. He had numerous publications, including important research papers in national and international journals by then.

For few days I remained confused about this statement, but could not gather the courage to go to him and ask for the explanation. Probably after about a week or so, I happened to go to his room, of course for some other purpose when I very hesitantly broke the subject. I tried to explain my confusion, by making statements about the tissues, organs and systems as we had been taught in last almost two years. He cut me short in between and in a fatherly tone told me to have the patience. He explained that since I have not studied Psychology as yet, (which, anyway unfortunately was not taught with the proper emphasis, it deserved, those days.) you will understand the things after some time. He

emphasized that brain functions is a complicated subject and there are many lacunae and dark spots which are not explainable at this stage. He advised me to keep up my enthusiasm intact and search for the answers afterwards.

And this is how a medical student who was burdened enough with his own studies started reading voraciously about anything and everything about human behavior he could lay his hands on. Sadly I did not focus on a particular subject or phenomenon, a bad habit I still continue with. I read few well known philosophers, a few books on psychology, palmistry, astrology along with autobiographies of some great people of the world. But with all this, at the end of the medical studies, I was as confused and bewildered about the relation of mind and brain, as I was when I was a second year medical student. But the quest, more or less remained and continued in spite of various difficulties I faced in my life afterwards.

Now, coming to the subject of this essay, I am to submit, very humbly, the following:

Philosophically and historically, India can be safely placed at the top position in the creation of knowledge of concepts of Mind. Our Vedic sages and seers have done deep contemplative meditation on this subject and deduced some conclusions about mind which cannot be refuted even today. These concepts are easily about five to seven thousand years old. Our Vedic Upnishads have plenty references to Mind, (mana) Individual Soul (Aatma) and Universal soul (pramaTma) and their relations to each other. In many of our scriptures, while discussing about elements of creation, a set of internal organs, The Antahkaranas are mentioned, apart from organs of action and senses, which are visible to the physical eye. These internal organs though invisible, govern, impact and effect the human life in myriad ways. These internal organs are; Mind (mana) Intellect (buddhi) and Ego (Ahamkara). Some authorities add another one as (Chit) the consciousness to this list. In this list, Mind is the most fascinating and difficult to control and manipulate. It is emphasized that mind is the fastest phenomenon,

(Jewishth)which can travel to any point in known and unknown universe almost in no time. Mind is the cradle of human thoughts, determinations and desires. After a thought is created, it is the job of the intellect to weigh it and decide about its utility or otherwise. The other organs of action and senses come into play afterwards. The mind is close to and in some peculiar way controlled by Atman- the individual soul. And Atman- the individual soul- and universal soul or the Ultimate Reality are one and the same phenomenon , though, not apprehended or appreciated so by an ordinary individual . This conception of unity of the two is one of the most profound and fundamental principles of Vedic thought and this conception is easily the highest ideal of our civilization. Let me quote Mr. Edmond Holmes, a renowned author and poet

“ the significance of this conception is not only metaphysical ,but there is a practical side to it as well. The unity of the all pervading life, in and through its own essential spirituality--- the unity of the trinity of the God and Nature and Man- is from man’s point of view- , an ideal to be realized rather than an accomplished fact.”

The scientific knowledge of the functioning of mind and brain and their physical relations, has started rather recently in our country in and around mid twentieth century. Now-a-days we have some very good institutions where scholars and researchers address these issues and the associated behavior which forms the foundation of the human civilization. Thus the strengths and the weaknesses of human mind have deep origins in the functioning of the brain. In fact the interdependence of the brain, mind and behavior is very earnestly studied in psychology and forensic science in addition to, the usual medical faculties. Recently, the discipline of Cognitive Neuropsychology has become very important to understand the human behavior in its varied situations.

A lot of research work is being done in our premier mental health and neuroscience institutes like the one at Bangluru named as National Institute of Mental Health and

Neurosciences (NIMHNS), which has almost all the faculties related to brain and mind like neurology, neurosurgery, neuroradiology , psychiatry, clinical and neuropsychology. Thus a multidisciplinary approach is adopted to study human behavior, and of course the abnormalities of it as happens in the disease states, and then remedies for these.

Many of us have heard about a renowned psychologist of our times , namely Daniel Kahneman. Sadly he passed away recently, in the last week of March,2024. He was an Israeli-American who got the nobel prize in “Economics” in 2002, which he shared with his fellow traveler , Amos Tversky. His studies and theories about human behavior created a new field of” Behavioral Economics”, which got international recognition by the coveted Nobel Prize. His contribution in teaching us how to think about thinking and thereby finding answers to the most important and basic questions that impact our lives, is his most lasting and valuable legacy. His views about human behavior are tragic, in a way. He demonstrated through his research papers and theories, that we are all, without exception, born with cognitive quirks, that make us deeply and inherently flawed. According to his theory, every human being thinks that the others are biased , but not me. And also, all of us have an unlimited ability to ignore our ignorance. He writes, “ A reliable way to make people believe in falsehoods is frequent repetition, because familiarity is not easily distinguishable from truth”. With these observations and derivations of human behavior leading to many of the economic phenomenon taking place from time to time- and thus he called it Behavioral Economics.

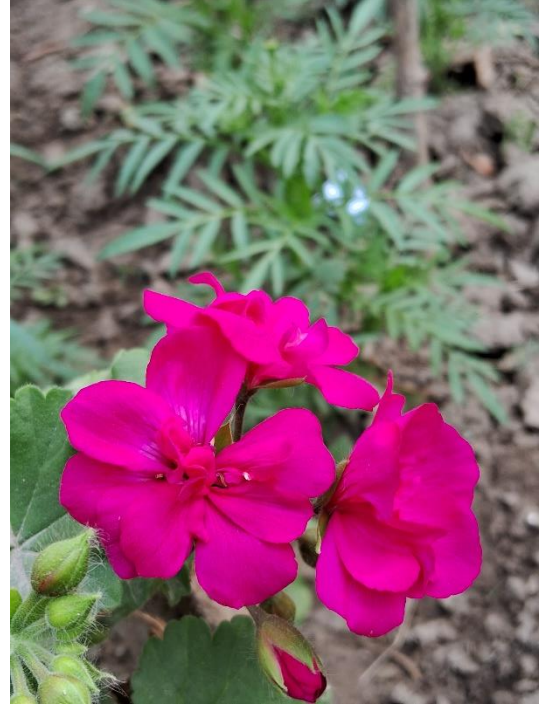
This whole discussion boils down to the fact that human thoughts shape the human behavior, which in turn will determine the quality of life of humanity as such. Since, now we know that thoughts are created in mind , processed in intellect for its worth or worthlessness before being implemented by brain through external organs of action and senses. Therefore let me end this discourse by invoking a prayer , the one from Shukla Yajurveda:

(Tan may manah shiv sankalpamastu)

May my mind always be full of noble and benevolent thoughts for one and all .)

Amen!

(Dr G.L Kaw is a retired medical practitioner based in Gandhinagar Gujarat with an avid interest in history, philosophy, classical Sanskrit and Persian literature)



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Yoga and Neuroplasticity



Bhoomi Sati

The brain's capacity to reorganise and modify its structure and function in response to experience, learning, and environmental changes is known as neuroplasticity or brain plasticity. It is the brain's extraordinary capacity to rearrange its connections, structure, and function in response to life experiences, learning, and environmental cues. This phenomena casts doubt on the long-held belief that, after a certain age, the structure of the brain is fixed and unchangeable. Rather, studies have demonstrated that the brain is extremely flexible and able to undergo substantial alterations in reaction to a variety of stimuli. Knowing the fundamentals of neuroplasticity has a significant impact on interventions, education, and rehabilitation that aim to support cognitive health and well-being throughout the lifespan. Through the use of the brain's natural plasticity, scientists and medical professionals can create novel approaches to improve learning, restore function that has been lost, and maintain optimal brain health across a range of demographics.

It has been discovered that yoga causes neuroplastic changes in the brain through the combination of physical postures (asanas), breathwork (pranayama), meditation, and mindfulness exercises. Studies on brain activity reveal that during physical movement, the brain regions in charge of cognitive processes—such as thinking, reasoning, evaluating, remembering, and feeling—are also active. This implies that, whether consciously or unconsciously, the ideas, feelings, and

perceptions encountered during yoga practice aid in the brain's training in those mental processes. Yoga is more than just physical exercise; it's about reflection and becoming aware of your inner sensations. During practice, it's critical to be aware of one's thoughts, feelings, and inner dialogue. The inner journey is just as important as the creation of new musculoskeletal patterns in the setting of neuroplasticity.

Research utilising neuroimaging methods, such as magnetic resonance imaging, or MRI, has shown that consistent yoga practice is linked to structural alterations in several brain regions. For instance, regions like the prefrontal cortex, insula, and hippocampus that are involved in attention, emotion regulation, and self-awareness have been shown to have higher grey matter densities. Studies also suggest that yoga and other behavioural therapies may be able to slow down the effects of ageing and neurodegenerative diseases.

Maintaining a regular yoga practice each week is associated with greater brain volume in regions linked to attention, self-relevance, visualization, stress coping, and physical embodiment. Additionally, as yoga experience grows, there's a correlation with increased brain volume in areas supporting autonomic regulation, emotional processing, hierarchical organization, and regions involved in monitoring transitions from painless to painful sensations or experiences associated with insights into universal unity, peace, and joy. These findings suggest that certain brain changes may endure even with years of consistent yoga practice. Preclinical research indicates that yoga may enhance synaptic plasticity—the reinforcing of neuronal connections—and neurogenesis—the production of new neurons—in areas related to learning and memory, including the prefrontal cortex and the hippocampus. The benefits of yoga practice in terms of cognitive function, memory consolidation, and adaptive behaviour may be attributed to these neuroplastic alterations.

In conclusion, there is strong evidence supporting the significant effects of yoga practices on the structure and function of the brain from the growing field of research on yoga and neuroplasticity. Yoga combines physical postures, breathwork, meditation, and mindfulness

practices to enhance mental health by utilising the brain's natural plasticity to support emotional stability, cognitive resilience, and general mental well-being. The neuroplastic benefits of yoga are still being better understood, but it is becoming abundantly evident that this age-old practice has enormous potential as a comprehensive intervention for promoting lifelong cognitive vibrancy and brain health. Through the practice of yoga, people can develop inner balance, self-awareness, and mindfulness. This can lead to a profound shift in neurological well-being and the realisation of the amazing ability of the brain to change, develop, and prosper throughout life.

(Bachelor's in Psychology from Indraprastha College for Women, Delhi University. Currently pursuing Master's in Psychology specialising in Behavioural Neuroscience from Concordia University, Montreal.)



Travelogue: A trip to Tarakund

A good traveller has no fixed plans, and is not intent on arriving – Lao Tzu



Rashneek Kher

It was one October evening, it doesn't matter what year or what date it was, it just was one such October evening. It was one of those days when I was utterly unhappy with who I am, who I was and was utterly confused about who I wanted to be and who I was ending up as. My career was as stagnant as an unkempt pond and the only joy in my life came from teaching students at a local college in Delhi. That too seemed to be giving what the economists would call "the law of diminishing returns".

In such situations we all want to run away from where we are, at least I wanted to. We want to seek solace in places that are unfamiliar, places where no one knows us and we know none. We want to reflect on our being and becoming or not-becoming for that matter. I started googling and looking for places that were "not on the map". After hours of searching I ended up stopping at a place called Tarakund Mahadev. There was a picture of what seemed like an old temple on the bank of a large pond. I tried to find more about the place but not much information seemed to come my way except that it was the highest point in Pauri district of Garhwal Mandal of Uttarakhand. There was no other information that could help us reach this place. The map showed that it was close to a small stopover called Paithani.

I finished my class and reported sick at my office. With no plan in mind, without much luggage and no bookings at all we began to drive towards the hills. We encountered unusually heavy traffic till we reached Meerut. Then we took the bypass to Najibabad and soon the traffic became lighter. The trees on both sides of the road formed a canopy and the autumn sun bore its subtleness in its pristine glory. We stopped for a while at an eatery called The Monty Millions. My driver was particularly impressed by the "quality" of the Paranthas there. In about an hour or a little more than an hour we could see the mountains. We downed our windows and let the fresh air of Kotdwar fill our lungs.

Kotdwar is a small town on the banks of river Khoh and serves as an entrance to the Pauri Garhwal region of Uttarakhand. It has a bustling market and a very large temple dedicated to Siddhbali (Lord Hanuman) which is frequented by devotees throughout the year. I have been a frequent traveller to the Garhwal region and seem to have developed not just familiarity with the region but also some kind of affinity with the nature. As is the custom in these hills the travellers stop by to pay obeisance to the Durga Devi temple which is about 12 kilometres ahead of Kotdwar. We stopped by this beautiful temple on the bank of the Khoh mountain stream. The Goddess is worshipped in the form of natural stalagmite formations in the cave. We said our prayers and sat down to meditate. The old priest quietly sat by, looking into the oblivion. When we bent to seek permission from the Mother Goddess to go further into the mountains, the old priest patted our backs and gave us prasad. The touch felt familiar though I can't say how.



The sun was beginning to set and I thought we should take rest for the night because we knew we were too far from our ultimate destination. An acquaintance owns a small guest house near Duggada. Without bothering to check if they have accommodation or not, we drove to the guest house called SB Mount Resorts. Thankfully they let us in and we started asking the staff if they had any inkling about how to go to Tarakund. Most of the people around had never heard of the place leave alone knowing how to get there. Undeterred, I told my driver to be ready at 5 AM in the morning for our sojourn. Around 9 PM in the evening we went down to the restaurant where we met a young Garhwali couple who not only knew the place but had even visited the temple. I thanked them profusely for the information which would serve as a guide for the trip.

We woke up early, washed and said our prayers. With the first ray of the sun we started driving towards Satpuli via Ghumkhal. There were mesmerizing views of the hills. The sun shone mildly over the pine forests. The unending bends in the roads were offering new vistas. It was as if Mother Nature was blessing us endlessly. We drove uphill till we reached Ghumkhal. From a distance we could see the Bhairva temple of the Kaal Bhairava Naath on the hill to our left. We bowed to the eternal Lord and sought blessings and kept driving down the hill until we saw a group of girls waving their hands and asking us to stop.



We stopped and the girls requested us if we could drop them to their school near Satpuli. One of the bold ones among them said, well you don't have to take a detour if you are going to Satpuli. There were five of them. I don't know they managed to fit themselves in the backseat of the SWIFT car but somehow, they did. They were dressed in sky blue kurtas and white pyjamas and their hair was tied up in red ribbons. Three of them were in Grade 7 and two in Grade 6. They kept chatting with each other and were occasionally giggling. We got talking and they asked me where I am from and what brought me here, and in the bargain, I asked them their names, their grades and whether they liked going to school or not. I know it might sound unreal to say this but I almost felt at that moment that I was in the company of Goddesses and the surreality of that moment lasts to this day. Our conversation lasted till we dropped them near their school in Satpuli. We bade good byes and I saw them taking a small path to their school.

We stopped by at Satpuli to fill our tank and also fill two cans of petrol. In the past this used to be the last

petrol pump in the region. However, after we filled our cans the petrol pump owner informed us that there is a filling station in Paithani. Satpuli is situated on the banks of the Nayar river which forms a tributary to the Ganga. Unlike its sister towns of Pauri or Lansdowne it has tropical vegetation and climate and is often very hot in the summers.

We crossed the bridge over Nayar river and turned right. We had the river to keep us company. After driving for about 45 minutes or so we stopped by at the shrine of Ma Jwalpa Devi. The local populace considers this shrine as a Shakti Peeth and they have immense faith associated with the shrine where the Goddess manifests as “Akhand Jyot” -The Eternal Light. There are many myths and legends associated with the place and according to one AdiShankara had a vision of the mother here. After we sought her blessings we kept on the road to Pabo.



Enroute to Pabo we saw small villages nestled in the hills and the terraced fields lent beauty to the view. The outside air was crisp and fresh. I seemed to have forgotten all about my office, my work, my woes and even my family. We stopped at Pabo to ask how far Paithani was and also to get our car tyres checked. After driving for about two and a half hours we finally reached Paithani around 2 PM.

I started asking people about TaraKund Mahadev and how I could go there. The young couple in Duggada had told me about one sweetmeat shop called Raj Hotel who would rent rooms to the tourists. The so-called hotel was one of the bigger shops in this small bazar. The owner of the shop said it takes a lot of time to reach Tara Kund from here but he could arrange to send someone with me who would guide me to the temple.

He made a few calls and asked me to wait. In about half an hour a young gentleman by the name of Deepak Rawat came and said he would take me to a village from where the ascent will be shorter and quicker but a little steeper. So, we got back into the car and started driving towards a village called Bhadet. The road was a narrow single lane road and wasn't really in a good condition but the views kept getting more and more majestic as we kept going uphill. We drove for about an hour until we arrived at quaint village called Bhadet.

We began our ascent to the temple. Initially there were scores of stairs and we kept climbing till we reached the end of the village. The stairs now gave way to the path which the villagers would use to go to the shrine or would use to take their animals for grazing up in the forests above the village. We had to be back before the sun set, so we were practically running up the hill. It was as one would call an uphill task. We would stop briefly to either click pictures or to take in the enthralling views of the lower Himalayas. We could see the entire village from a vantage position. Women were descending the mountain with heavy loads of firewood on their backs. They were singing songs in local dialect. Their voices had subtle naivete about them as if they were untouched by the civilization around them. After about an hour and half of intense climbing we reached a plateau or maybe it was shaped like a shallow bowl.



I couldn't help but hold my breath for that moment when I savoured what I saw. It had been a journey where I wasn't even sure if I would get here in the first place. In front of us was a virgin meadow with a large pond (glacial fed or even rain fed) and at the western end of the pond was a temple of some antiquity. On the Kalash of the temple were the words- Jai Maa Tara.

Between the temple and the large pond was a small well. We drew water from the well and offered it to the Lord. I sat in the sanctum sanctorum which was bereft of any regalia that is generally associated with the temples. In its bareness it was ornate, complete in itself.

The vacuity that had led me to discover myself was getting filled with a sense of belongingness to the supreme or the self. The feeling of sublimity that I felt here was akin to the one that I felt at the small temple of Shiva Bhagwati in Akinggam, Anantnag. Inside my head the questions were beginning to subside and were giving way to emotions that swell up when one sees one's mother after a long time. After reciting my Japa for some time, I rendered Laghustava a little loudly and tears come down my eyes as I was rendering the hymns to the Mother Goddess. Inside my heart I thanked my master without whose divine grace I wouldn't have even known whatever infinitesimally little knowledge of self I have.

As with most of the hoary shrines there are infinite myths and legends associated with this temple also. There is a large stone on the eastern periphery of the pond. The locals here believe that underneath the stone is cave in which an old lady lived and prayed. This lady goes by the name "Kund ki Beni" or the sister of the Kund. It is widely believed that during her lifetime the cave was guarded by lions. People in the area have stories about her being seen even today.

The other more prevalent belief is that it is here that the Goddess Tara, considered as the daughter of Daksh Prajapati the king of Kankhal, Haridwar and the sister of Goddess Sati would practice austerities and asceticism in order to propitiate Lord Shiva. I am not very sure but the locals say that there are Puranic references to Tantrics worshipping Goddess Tara here. The learned ones in the village say that the Kund Ki Beni is no one else but Mother Tara herself. People also say that the entire Tara-Mandal is reflected in the pond and it is believed that the first morning star bathes itself in the water of this sacred pond. There are folk songs which affirm this belief.

The day had come to a metaphorical close. A certain sense of calm had dawned on me as I started my trek downwards. The shepherds were herding their cattle

and singing as the moon made its presence felt on the firmament.

(Rashneek Kher is a student of literature, particularly poetry and loves to travel to the mountains)



Ishwar Pratibhijna Karika

Karika1:

कर्तरिज्ञातरि स्वात्मन्यादिसिद्धेमहेश्
वरे
अजडात्मानिषेधंवा सिद्धिंवाविदधीतकः।

Kartari jnatari swatmanyadi siddhe maheshware
Ajadatma nishedham we sidhim va vidadhati kah |

Translation and Exposition:

Only a dunce[jada] and not an ajada or intelligent man would try to prove or disapprove of the Maheshwara .
Who is almighty, omniscient ,the universal self and self evident .

Karika2:

Kintu mohavashadasmin dristepyanupalakshite
Shaktyavushkaraneyam pratyabhijnopadarshyate |

किंतुमोहवशादस्मिन्दृष्टेप्यनुपलक्षिते
शक्त्याविष्करणेनेयं प्रत्यभिज्ञोपदृश्यते।

Translation and Exposition:

Justifying the compilation of this canon Utpalacharya says ,nevertheless this pratyabhijna has been propounded by unveiling the shakti or power of gnosis. He is observed alright, but not as the essential nature owing to moha or misgivings.

Due to an innate delusion or maya the conditioned experient is not able to identify himself with his essential nature which is self evident so in order to instruct the aspirant, his special magnanimity, this doctrine of pratyabhijna which conduces to a firm commitment is being presented here in this canon . There are two catagories of all entities sentient and insentient . Insentient entities depend on the sentient ones for the vindication of their existence . Sentience of conscious beings in turn is characterized by jnana and kriya i.e. gnosis and activity.

In ancient treatise on mysticism there are three modes of existence –ajna, atajna , and jna . conscious i.e. conscious of their pure subjective nature ,unconscious and not conscious of themselves ,conscious of themselves and others too. In all these three conditions conscious entity is aware of his own subjective and conscious nature and sentient or insentient disposition of other entities . From a philosophic perspective only the sentient or conscious one can be a proof of existence of an insentient or

unconscious entity . Knowledge and action distinguish a living entity from the insentient ones .These two are defined in the next aphorism.

Karika3:

Tatra jnanam swatah sidham
Kriya kayashrita sati
Parairapyuplakshyet
Tayanyajnanam uhyate

तत्रज्ञानंस्वतःस्वम् क्रियाकायाश्रितासती
परैरप्युलक्ष्येततयान्यज्ञानमूह्यते।

Translation and Exposition:

Jnanam or knowledge is self evident .Gross body is the agency of kriya or action . the knowledge proven as self evident as the ishvara universal self is the self of one's own and also as that of others. This ishvara veils himself with his maya shakti and hence the misidentification . Jnanam is self evident no other entity is required to know the knower , jnanam as such has no distinctions of subjective or objective description.

Karika 4:

Nanu swalakshanabhasam jnanam ekam param punah
Sabhilapam vikalpakhyam bahudha napi tadvayam .
ननु स्वलक्षणाभासं ज्ञानमेकंपरंपुनःसाभिलापं
विकल्पाख्यंबहुधानापितद्वयम्।४।

Translation and Exposition:

There is an interjection from skeptics and determinists, they opine that the self is eternal and conscious in nature is not consistent. Eternity and self luminance are not evident . Since only such notions of gnosis as appearance, doubt, recognition, recollection or discovery of an object say for example a jar or ghatam , can be consistent but not in the case of eternity or illuminant nature or the self .Such gnosis is called sabhilapam vikalpa or expressible ideation .The cause of varieties in ideation or vikalpa has been defined as abhilapa by Abhinavgupta and manifests in the form of expressible word . Such vikalpa is also multifarious and not dual.

Karika 5:

Nityasya kasyachit drishtuh tasya atranavbhasatah
Ahampratitirapyesha shariradyavasayini
नित्यस्यकस्यचीद्रष्टुःतस्यात्रानवभासतः
अहंप्रतीतिरप्येषाशरीराद्यवसायिनी।५।

Translation and Exposition:

Owing to an absence of the appearance of any eternal witnessing consciousness, the experience of this notion

- aham also pertains only to "body" etc. . Even with a notion of the self or Aham and its verbal divergence no other entity that transcends the body etc. is experienced by anyone in a common parlance.

The counterargument by a theist is given as .
If an eternal self were not to be there how can there be a memory of an experience even after the stimulus has come to an end .Thus there must be an atman who is eternal and the experiencer of the stimulus ..

Questions

A. This karika describes the futility of proving existence of Maheshwara owing to his

- 1 discreet nature
- 2 inability of any mortal in doing so
- 3 he is beyond expression
- 4 none of the above

B.Only those who are stupid enough not to understand that Maheshwara or the great lord is self luminent ,omnipresent and omniscient would prove his existence rationally

- 1,true
- 2 false
- 3 cant say

C This pratyabhijna is enunciated to discover the shakti to recognise the self which is evident but still not recognised as the immediate self

- 1 true
- 2 false
- 3 cant say

D The attributes of sentient entities is

- 1 reproduction respiration , locomotion and response to stimuli
- 2 speaking and reasoning
- 3 action and seeing
- 4 none of these

E The delusion that causes the concealing of the evident Maheshwara

- 1 is the tirodhan shakti
- 2 maya shakti
- 3 both

4 none

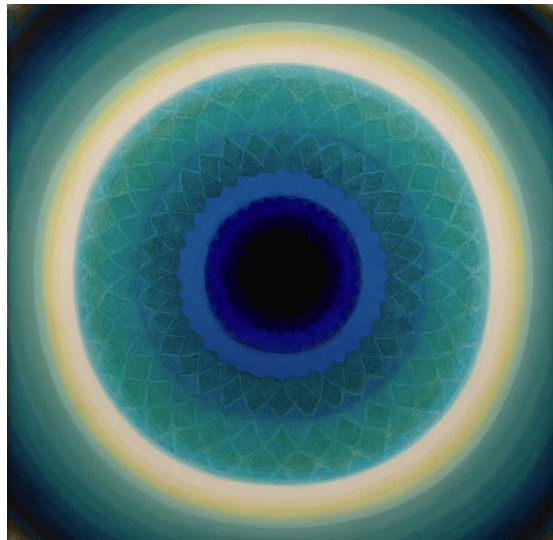
F An atheist refutes the existence of an atman and gives arguments to support his opinion that the notion of "self" or aham culminates into the awareness of the the body etc. because

- 1 the body is most important to a man
- 2 there is no subtle body
- 3 there is no experience of any permanent witness
- 4 none of the above



The science of Shakti 4

Shakti vijnanam of Somanand Nath



Artist: Biren De
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बोधनम्

After arousal of the kundalini the sixth step is Bodhanam or Awakening the power of consciousness which is manipulated through tantric means to enter the middle passage. It averts sidereal movements and heads straight up. The preceding step takes place in the muladhara whereas the sixth step bodhanam takes place in kanda (two fingers above genitals and five fingers below navel. The text reads “seated in the Kanda an aspirant should pierce navel or the navel plexus. Swacchanda tantra calls it piercing with the needle of vimarsha. Albeit the process of awakening starts as soon as Shakti rises up to kanda. Kanda is the cluster of myriad nadis or subtle ducts carrying various aspects of vital prana.

Depiction of the six plexuses or षट्चक्रनिरूपणं

Navel Plexus

Heart Plexus

Throat Plexus

Palate

Between the eye brows

Orifice of Brahma

describes the phenomena as the kundalini who remains coiled around the Swayambhu lingam self evident lingam veils the opening of the middle passage Susumna with her mouth . Through the tactics of mindful breathing techniques or Bhasrika the clog of vasa or fat is cleared and the serpent power enters the orifice . Another technique suggested for awakening or bodhanam in hathyoga pradeepiks is Shakti

sanchalini mudra . While the aspirant contracts his sphincters places his right ankle on the foot of his left thigh and holds his left toe with both hands bringing the nose close to the knee and syncs the breathing process with this posture kundalini awakens like a snake struck with a stick दंडाहत इवोरगः ।

This tactic of somanands school doesn't seem to be encouraging such “as if by force “ stuff but confided to the aspirant of trika system a सुखोपायः

Easy to accomplish process . Arousal (see the 5th article)needs some exercise of will power and mindful breathing kumbhaka and the Shakti as the divine mother of the universe rises up to unite with the absolute principle param Shiva .

मूलालवाल कुहरादुदिताभवानि

निर्भिद्यष्टसरसिजानि तडिल्लतेव

भूयोपितत्रविशसिधुवमंडलेंदुनिष्यंदमानपरमामृतेयरूपा ।

“O consort of Bhava you arise from the dismal aperture of muladhara chakra penetrate the six plexuses like a streak of lightening .as you rise to unite with shiva who manifests as the eternally bloomed full moon in the thousand petal plexus ,on your way back you irrigate the entire phenomena in the form of fluid ambrosia.”

All thirteen steps of this canon are encrypted in the above verse . Being a sentient entity who responds to the impetus of faith and devotion the process of awaking or bodhanam gets more and more spontaneous as we head towards subtler steps . The exponent of yoga aphorism sage Patanjali opines तीव्रसंवेगानीमासत्रः

The span of process of entering a trance of super consciousness is shortened as the intensity of motivation is enhanced

The reticulum of ducts pervading the subtle body must be familiarised before delving into the intricacies of this science of Shakti . All subtle passages which pervade the subtle body converge into 72000 then 72 then 14 and finally three. Corresponding regions of the fourteen Nadis in the gross body are ten organs of knowledge and action plus mind reason heart and ego (ज्ञानेन्द्रियाणि कर्मेन्द्रियाणि मनबुद्धि चित्तं अहंकारश्च) This entry into the Susumna begins in the Muladhara chakra where the awakened Shakti rises from the middle of mulachakra. Vedha and bodha seem to have been used as synonyms since both are also interdependent. The yogi should manipulate the Shakti in order to transcend the anahat chakra or the cardiac

plexus named as the abode of Brahma the creator in other tantras this phenomena is so-called “piercing the knot of brahma “ ब्रह्मग्रंथि भेदनम् . The location of this granthi is different in other tantras. The idea of muladhara as the seat of Brahma granthi manipura as Vishnu granthi and between ajna chakra as the seat of Rudra is from the standpoint of karma Bhakti and Jnana which are comparable to the agencies of kriya iccha and jnana. Since all these three are futile in having an intuitive insight into the essential nature their realms must be transcended if not bypassed. Just as Visranti chakra in other agamas is in the muladhara in kaula practices it is in svadhishtanam or kanda . The kundalini is aroused from Mula to svadhishtan and then reverted back to Mula. The actual arousal upto Bhrahmandhra or Bhairav bill is possible at the time of departure till then the aspirant circulates his kundalini between the two plexuses and abides by the precepts meant for a kaula. Hence the adage ‘jeevanmuktasch kaulika. A kaula is ever emancipated. Since anahat nada begins to be heard even in the plexus. All plexus are synthesised into the anahat chakra with 12 petals 10 plexus of manipura and 2 plexus of muladhara and svadhishtan therefore the seat of Brahma in Agama tantras like Swacchanda etc is heart plexus.. According to Mahakal Samhita the taints of brahma Vishnu and Rudra are anav Mayiya and karmam where as the taint of ishwara is Aishwarya and that of sadashiva is aham kara. Para Shambhu is ever taintless and pure the idea behind the Veda or exercising will power reinforced by the force of gnosis or vimarsha is to discard all these limiting conditionings. This can be possible only when awareness identifies with these and then shreds their realms by assimilating and transcending. This phenomena has been termed as Veda. it is not an ordinary task for a commoner to discard all injunctions of subservience to god almighty who manifests in these three or let’s say five forms. The impetus must come from a preceptor who has himself transcended all these streams. His compassion munificence says one of the popular hymns , accounts for shambhav Veda Deeksha

कारुण्यतो भवति शंभव वेधदीक्षा ।

The impetus for transcending these realms of brahma in the heart , Vishnu in the thoracic region Rudra in the palate come from the intensity of devotion on the part of an aspirant and the potency of shaktipat with all its gradation from the gurus side .



Artist: Biren De

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These are merely their corresponding locus in the aspirants physical body as the aspirants identifies with these respective realms and transcends them to access higher realms upto the ajnachakra where as per this system of mysticism there lies the seat of sadashiva ,one must have discarded any trace of identification with the gross or subtle body .

Piercing the realm of ishwara and the maxim of monkey and coconut . Bursting of the Bindu happens similar to a monkey’s (or in some texts the islanders of monkey island)finding coconut water and edible part after removing the husk and breaking the shell .By breaking the shell of Bindu an aspirant finds his way to nada nadant Shakti vyapini samani and unmani successively . The shell can be comparable to रोधिनी a gradation mediating Bindu and nada in which nature served the purpose of hurling awareness back into the gross conventional realm and to thwart the entry of an incompetent aspirant into the subtler realms .

To be cntd.

*Practitioners of “strenuous effort “

By

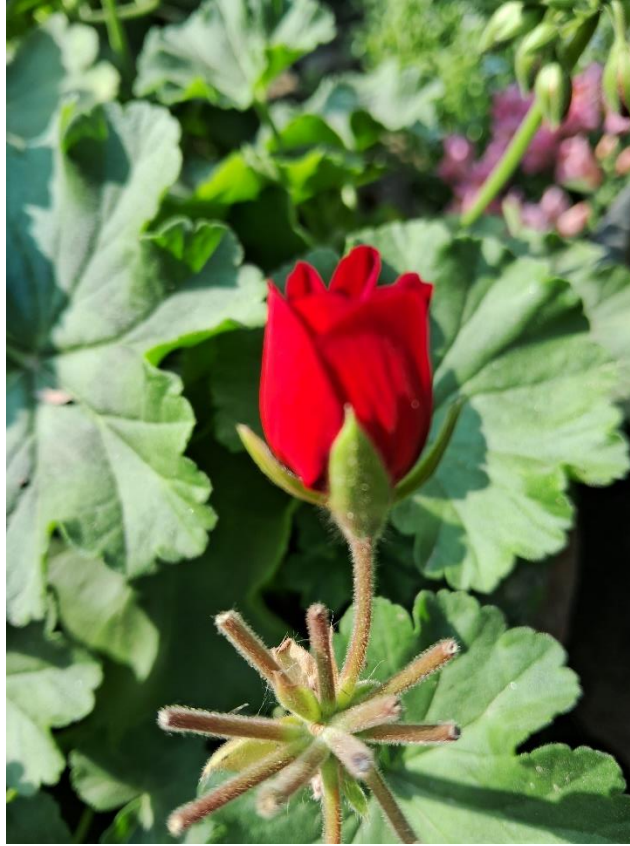
Varni Paratpar swarup

A brief insight in the online classes conducted by YTA

In the Yogtantragama Study Circle we read and discuss many arcane texts in the divine guidance of our Guru Maharaj Swami Paranand Tirth ji. Swamiji reads and explains the metaphysical import of these texts along with conventional commentaries.

Currently we are studying the 11th Chapter of Tantraloka and Prapanchsara Tantra. Swamiji explains the cryptic text and expositions in a manner that we can grasp it better and go beyond the literal meaning.

In last few months we have completed the study of Yogini Hrdaya, 'Swacchanda Tantra' and few patalas of Sharada Tilaka Tantra. Though the classes are in Sanskrit with a little patience and self study one can immensely benefit from them. Anyone interested to join us may please request Swamiji for the link.



After the Rain

~ Ambika Talwar



After the Rain

~ Ambika Talwar

Gold and silver lights rise from the
black-grey tarmac where rain is delicate,
subtle like your glancing smile.

Like that day when I saw your face in the
rose garden – where possibility peered,
petals fragrant with innocence.

Let beauty of the world rise like this –
Soul peering behind moments, a tender secret,
subtle gold-silver wings flash by in shadow.

Let streets smile where you walk – when
rain falls in dust and runs speedily in rivulets,
we contain ourselves as seeds for a new story.

Dark roots nourish earth, spread shoots up
to vault of heaven where nothing is forbidden.
May the beauty of the world be what we do.
May the beauty of the world be the becoming.

#

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(Ambika Talwar is an India-born author, poet, wellness consultant, artist, and educator whose vision is to realize her sacred destiny and invite others to brilliance. She has authored *4 Stars and 25 Roses* (poems for her father) and *My Greece: Mirrors & Metamorphoses* about her travels through Greece in 2002.)





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